

The Postmen



Becky! Internet Mail

Becky! Internet Mail 2.29 is a mere 2.3 MB download, and starts up very quickly, probably due to its no-frills interface.

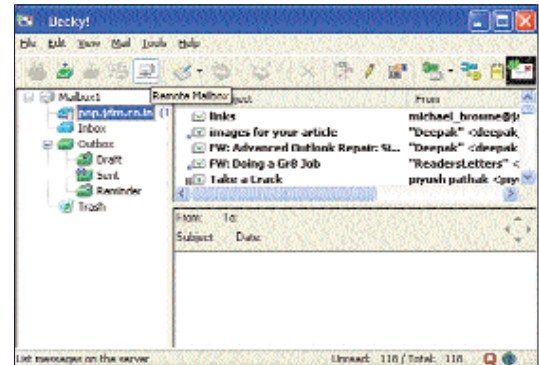
Becky! Internet Mail does not have a polished interface; attention seems to have been paid only to functionality. There are no Wizards or guides, and a newbie will feel lost. However, the simple menus do everything one would expect of an e-mail client.

While it supports HTML e-mail composing to some extent, it can hook up to an external editor such as Word to enhance your composition. This is a configurable option. If you attempt to enter ActiveX content into the mail, Becky! will warn you about its potential dangers. You can even directly edit mail in the viewer window, and this can even be the HTML message you created earlier using the external application.

The search as well as the mail rules are a pain to understand, and not very customisable. Becky! has a unique Reminder capability, using which

you can send yourself an e-mail and specify the date when you wish to receive it. The Mailing Lists Manager helps you maintain multiple mailing list subscriptions. Becky! also comes with a PGP (Pretty Good Privacy) plug-in preinstalled, which lets you encrypt messages before sending them.

Becky! has a feature called the Remote Mailbox, which lets you decide whether to delete or download a certain mail or mails while they're still on the server. All basic mail functions such as copy, paste, delete, forward, reply and drag-and-drop are supported when using the Remote Mailbox feature. Becky! is, however, priced at \$40 (Rs 1,800), which seems too much for just an e-mail client.



Becky's Remote Mailbox lets you preview your mails

What We Looked For

Protocol support

POP3: Post Office Protocol version 3 is an application-layer Internet standard protocol that lets you retrieve e-mail from a remote mail server over the Internet. Many e-mail service providers provide a free POP3 service, while some such as Yahoo! provide it for a fee.

IMAP: This was earlier known variously as Internet Mail Access Protocol, Interactive Mail Access Protocol, and Interim Mail Access Protocol. This is an application-layer Internet protocol that allows a local client to access e-mail on a remote server. It is also known as IMAP4. Almost all modern e-mail clients and servers support it.

NNTP: Network News Transfer Protocol is an Internet application protocol primarily used for reading and posting Usenet articles, as well as to transfer news among news servers.

News Feeds: This is a family of Web feed formats used to publish frequently-updated digital content such as blogs, news feeds, and podcasts. It is again divided into formats such as ATOM and RSS (Rich Site Summary); the latter again has versions 0.91, 1.0, and 2.0.

Security features

SSL encryption: Secure Sockets Layer is a cryptographic protocol that provides secure communications on the Internet for things such as e-mail, Web browsing, Internet faxing, and other data communications and transfers.

Preview before download: Some e-mail clients support reading mail off the POP3 server directly without downloading it to the PC. This provides you with security against malicious e-mail. The image-blocking feature also has the same advantages.

Junk filtering: Spam can be irritating and also means a waste of time. Inbuilt Junk/Spam filters are therefore a big plus.

Appearance

Formatted mails: HTML-formatted messages have much better visual appeal than plain-text messages.

Customisable Interface And Keybindings: The interface and keybindings (combinations of keystrokes) should be customisable to suit individual needs.

Mail Notification: Mail notifiers alert you when you receive a new mail so you don't need to keep checking for new mails.

Ease Of Use: We looked at the ease with which a new mail account could be created, whether the interface is user-friendly, and so on, and collectively rated this on a scale of five.

PIM features

Personal Information Manager features such as Calendar, Notes, Tasks, Scheduler, Memo, etc. were noted. Though these aren't that important for the home user, they don't hurt!

Other features

Split large attachments: Most e-mail service providers specify a certain size limit for the attachments you can send. Anything above this size is rejected. The option we're talking about lets you split attachments to a size below the specified threshold.

Import/Export Of Mail And Address Book: This is an important feature—very useful when you're migrating from one e-mail client to another. An e-mail client should support importing from as many popular clients as possible.

Multiple Profile Support: For more than one user to access a mail client installation, the client should be able to handle a profile unique to each user.

Changeable Mail Store Location: It is a good idea to change the location of the e-mails stored locally on the hard drive to a safer-than-default location (such as a drive other than the one where the OS resides).

Plug-in Support: Plug-ins have the power to completely revamp an e-mail client, so this is a very welcome feature.

Additional features: We looked for any additional features to the above that the e-mail client offered.